early 1960s, the Soviets began to provide combat systems such as MiG-21 fighter aircraft. [42]

For its part, the United States during President Dwight D. Eisenhower's second term, while concerned by India's improved relationship with Moscow, was also more reconciled to New Delhi's Non-Alignment than previous administrations. During and after Nehru's 1956 visit to the United States and improved rapport with Eisenhower, both the United States and India tried to downplay their many differences and work toward advancing India's economic prospects as a bulwark against Chinese Communism. This contributed to a substantial increase in US aid to India in the late 1950s and early 1960s. [43] For a brief period, in practice, India's Non-Alignment truly made it, in the words of Polish economist Michal Kalecki, one of 'the proverbial clever calves that suck two cows'. [44] An enduring and illustrative manifestation of this involved the establishment of the Indian Institutes of Technology (IIT), now a pride of Indian higher education, having produced generations of world-class talent. The first IITs at Kharagpur, Bombay, Madras, Delhi, and Kanpur were established between 1950 and 1961 with assistance from a consortium of leading American universities, the Soviet Union, the United Nations, West Germany, and the United Kingdom. [45]

But even in the 1950s itself, India's balancing act began to look precarious. India did not vociferously criticize the Soviet Union's actions during the Hungarian Revolution, which contrasted with its denunciation of Britain, France, and Israel during the Suez Crisis in 1956. In private, the United States agreed with India on Britain's recklessness in the Suez but was less happy about its stance on Hungary. Nevertheless, its contrasting approaches to the two situations lost New Delhi some of the credibility that it had developed in the first half of the decade. Some of the criticism was domestic in nature: 'By kowtowing to Russia we have abdicated our moral pretensions,' argued one Indian journalist at the time. [46] Other domestic critics of India's double standards included the activist and political leader Jayaprakash Narayan. [47] Moreover, India's efforts at mediation in Korea, Indochina (modern Vietnam, Laos, and Cambodia), the Taiwan Strait, or Lebanon in the 1950s were not perceived favourably by many of the parties